
Succeeding When No One Did It Before You

The first-gen vertigo: moving forward where no path was traced

4 psychology approaches · by EvaTalk

TO BEGIN

The first-gen vertigo: moving forward where no path was traced

Being the first in your family to study, to leave precarity, to start a business: it's moving forward without a map, with the feeling of being 'between two worlds' and the guilt of leaving your people behind. It's exhilarating... and dizzying.

This guide helps you inhabit your new place without denying where you come from.

YOUR INTENTION

What weighs on you most about being 'the first one': _____

Moving forward without a map

When no one traced the path before you, everything is to invent: no model, unfamiliar codes, and often a feeling of being 'neither from here nor there'. This experience (sometimes called class crossing) is real and widely shared — you aren't the 'abnormal' one.

Understanding it normalizes the vertigo: it's the price of a pioneering path, not a flaw.

Example

Léa felt illegitimate everywhere; understanding the class-crosser experience freed her of guilt.

My in-between

Where do you feel this 'neither here nor there' most?

Pioneer

Write: 'I move forward without a map: it's pioneering, not abnormal.'

Takeaway — Being the first means moving without a map — a normal vertigo, not a flaw.

'I don't belong here'

'I don't belong here', 'I'll be exposed', 'I betray my people': these thoughts, between impostor syndrome and guilt, brake you at the worst moment.

Reframing them lets you occupy the place you've earned.

Example

'I have no business here' paralyzed Sami in his new milieu, until he saw he fully belonged.

Spot the brake

Note an illegitimacy or betrayal thought · a fairer version.

My place

Write: 'I earned my place; I have the right to occupy it.'

Takeaway — You're not an impostor: you earned your place, and you betrayed no one.

Honor your origins AND your new place

You don't have to choose between where you come from and where you're going: you can belong to both. Your origins are a strength and a pride, not a shame to hide; and your success isn't a denial.

You're a bridge between two worlds — a richness, not a tearing to endure.

Example

By no longer denying her origins, Nia turned her 'in-between' into a singular strength.

My two worlds

How to honor both your origins and your new place?

A bridge

Write: 'I can belong to both my worlds.'

Takeaway — You can honor your origins AND fully occupy your new place.

Draw your map, surround yourself

In practice: build your own roadmap (since there isn't one), find mentors and peers who lived the same transition (they understand you), manage the guilt and family dynamics (talk, reassure, keep the bond), and learn to hold your two worlds without tearing yourself. You also open the way for those who follow.

The pioneer doesn't find the map: they draw it — and leave it to those who come next.

Example

By finding a mentor who'd been through it, Karim moved far more serenely in his new world.

My support

A mentor, peer or anchor to find so you don't move forward alone: _____

Draw it

Write: 'I draw my map, and I open the way.'

Takeaway — Draw your own map and surround yourself with peers who understand your transition.

Key takeaways

- Being the first means moving without a map — a normal vertigo, not a flaw.
- The class-crosser experience ('neither here nor there') is real and shared.
- You're not an impostor: you earned your place.
- You can honor your origins AND your new place — a bridge, not a tearing.
- Find mentors and peers who lived the same transition.
- You draw your map — and open the way for those who follow.

Your turn

My in-between

Where I feel it	The illegitimacy thought

My path

Honor my two worlds	My support to find

YOUR JOURNEY

Your 4-week plan

Week 1

Understand the class-crosser experience.

Week 2

Reframe 'I don't belong here'.

Week 3

Honor my origins AND my new place.

Week 4

Find a mentor/peer and draw my map.

YOUR PLAN

Your action plan

My 'I earned my place' line:

How I honor my two worlds:

The mentor / peer to find:

You don't move forward only for yourself: you open a path for those who follow.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not therapy. For heavy inheritances (deep shame, stubborn family patterns), support (a psychologist or psychotherapist) is a precious help. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.